

Ex.No.9 Use Process Explorer to identify suspicious processes

Description

Process Explorer is a powerful Windows tool that provides detailed information about running processes, allowing users to monitor, troubleshoot, and detect suspicious activities. It can be used to detect potential malware or harmful processes by analyzing various aspects of running applications.

Here's a step-by-step guide on how to use Process Explorer to identify suspicious processes on your system:

Step 1: Download and Set Up Process Explorer

1. Download Process Explorer:

- Go to the official Microsoft Sysinternals website and download Process Explorer: [Download Process Explorer](#).

2. Extract the Program:

- Once downloaded, extract the ZIP file to a folder.

3. Run Process Explorer:

- Open the folder where you extracted the files and run `procexp64.exe` (64-bit) or `procexp.exe` (32-bit) as Administrator by right-clicking and selecting "Run as Administrator."

Step 2: Familiarize Yourself with the Interface

When Process Explorer starts, you'll see an interface that lists all running processes, showing their hierarchy, memory usage, CPU usage, and much more.

1. Process Tree:

- The main window shows a tree of all running processes, with each child process listed under its parent.
- Processes are color-coded to indicate their status:
 - Pink: Suspended processes.
 - Light Blue: Processes running under the same user as you.
 - Dark Blue: Services or processes running under system accounts.

- **Green:** New processes (appearing and disappearing quickly may be suspicious).
- **Red:** Processes that have just exited.

2. Columns:

- Various columns show information such as Process ID (PID), CPU usage, Memory usage, and more.

```

Windows PowerShell
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PS C:\Users\ashra> cd "D:\DIGITAL FORENSIC\EXP 9\ProcessExplorer"
PS D:\DIGITAL FORENSIC\EXP 9\ProcessExplorer> Get-ChildItem

Directory: D:\DIGITAL FORENSIC\EXP 9\ProcessExplorer

Mode                LastWriteTime         Length Name
----                -
-a-----         22-09-2026    09:14             7490 Eula.txt
-a-----         22-09-2026    09:14         4619544 procexp.exe
-a-----         22-09-2026    09:14         2419992 procexp64.exe
-a-----         22-09-2026    09:14         2463512 procexp64a.exe

PS D:\DIGITAL FORENSIC\EXP 9\ProcessExplorer> Start-Process ".\procexp64.exe" -Verb RunAs
PS D:\DIGITAL FORENSIC\EXP 9\ProcessExplorer> |

```

Step 3: Identify Suspicious Processes

Now that you are familiar with the interface, follow these steps to investigate potentially suspicious processes:

1. Look for Unfamiliar Processes:

- Scan the list of running processes and identify any names that you don't recognize. Some malware disguises itself with legitimate-looking names, but odd names can be a red flag.
- Legitimate processes should typically be from trusted sources (e.g., Microsoft, Intel, Adobe, etc.).

2. Verify Digital Signatures:

- Right-click any suspicious process and select Properties.
- Go to the Image tab and check if the process has a valid Digital Signature.
- Legitimate applications from trusted developers will have valid signatures. Processes without signatures or with invalid signatures are suspicious.

3. Check the Path of the Process:

- In the Properties window of the suspicious process, look under the Image tab for the Path.
- Verify if the process is located in a legitimate directory. For example, legitimate system processes should reside in C:\Windows\System32.
- If the process is running from a temporary folder, user folder, or a random directory, it might be malware.

4. Monitor CPU, Memory, and Disk Usage:

- Look at the CPU, Memory, and Disk usage columns.
- A process that is using an unusual amount of resources without explanation could be malicious. For example, high CPU usage on a process like svchost.exe can indicate malware.

5. Check Process Description and Company Name:

- Look at the Description and Company Name columns in Process Explorer.
- Legitimate processes usually provide clear descriptions and are tied to well-known companies.
- Lack of information or suspicious company names should prompt further investigation.

6. Check the Process Network Activity:

- Some malware communicates with external servers. You can inspect a process's network connections:
 - Right-click on the process and select Properties, then go to the TCP/IP tab to see network activity associated with the process.
 - Unexpected or unexplained external connections can indicate a malicious process.

Step 4: Perform a Google Search on Suspicious Processes

If you find a process that looks suspicious or unfamiliar:

1. Search online: Perform a quick Google search using the process name (e.g., processname.exe) to find out whether the process is known to be safe or malicious.
2. Check Malware Databases: Use online databases such as VirusTotal or ProcessLibrary to verify whether the process is known for being part of malware.

Process Explorer - Sysinternals: www.sysinternals.com [LAPTOP-1C14CNS1\ashra] (Administrator)

File Options View Process Find Users Help

<Filter by name>

Process	CPU	Private Bytes	Working Set	PID	Description	Company Name
Secure System		176 K	68,072 K	188		
Registry		12,568 K	58,504 K	232		
System Idle Process	79.33	60 K	8 K	0		
System	1.67	52 K	3,968 K	4		
Interrupts	1.19	0 K	0 K	n/a	Hardware Interrupts and DPCs	
smss.exe		1,168 K	1,516 K	868		
Memory Compression	< 0.01	2,220 K	3,72,248 K	3352		
csrss.exe		2,656 K	7,464 K	1380		
wininit.exe		1,772 K	9,688 K	1596		
services.exe	< 0.01	7,812 K	20,236 K	1740		
svchost.exe	< 0.01	20,992 K	48,844 K	1900	Host Process for Windows S...	Microsoft Corporation
unsecapp.exe		2,948 K	13,736 K	5320	Sink to receive asynchronous...	Microsoft Corporation
WmiPrvSE.exe	< 0.01	29,320 K	31,744 K	5384	WMI Provider Host	Microsoft Corporation
WmiPrvSE.exe	0.59	20,704 K	39,496 K	3344	WMI Provider Host	Microsoft Corporation
CrossDeviceService.exe		30,260 K	1,06,828 K	11396	Microsoft Cross Device Servi...	Microsoft Corporation
PushNotificationsLongR...		2,104 K	17,844 K	18656	PushNotificationsLongRunnin...	Microsoft Corporation
SearchHost.exe	0.48	75,040 K	1,47,876 K	13032		Microsoft Corporation
msedgewebview2.exe	< 0.01	51,552 K	1,37,452 K	17776	Microsoft Edge WebView2	Microsoft Corporation
msedgewebview2.exe		2,996 K	12,844 K	23172	Microsoft Edge WebView2	Microsoft Corporation
msedgewebview2.exe		15,920 K	43,836 K	28760	Microsoft Edge WebView2	Microsoft Corporation
msedgewebview2.exe	< 0.01	1,51,928 K	1,41,976 K	18992	Microsoft Edge WebView2	Microsoft Corporation
msedgewebview2.exe		9,408 K	20,680 K	26752	Microsoft Edge WebView2	Microsoft Corporation
msedgewebview2.exe	< 0.01	1,28,880 K	1,78,320 K	10460	Microsoft Edge WebView2	Microsoft Corporation
StartMenuExperienceHo...	< 0.01	94,236 K	1,49,496 K	19708	Windows Start Experience H...	Microsoft Corporation
WidgetBoard.exe		5,276 K	33,356 K	6336		Microsoft Corporation
RuntimeBroker.exe	< 0.01	18,332 K	74,540 K	11600	Runtime Broker	Microsoft Corporation
WidgetService.exe		5,344 K	25,960 K	21496	WidgetService.exe	Microsoft Corporation
RuntimeBroker.exe		2,360 K	13,968 K	25272	Runtime Broker	Microsoft Corporation
MicrosoftStartFeedProvi...		11,760 K	50,584 K	10344		Microsoft Corporation
TextInputHost.exe	< 0.01	1,39,704 K	1,95,044 K	16296		Microsoft Corporation

CPU Usage: 20.58% Commit Charge: 52.81% Processes: 267 Physical Usage: 71.56%

Step 5: Kill or Suspend Suspicious Processes

If you find a process that you believe is malicious:

1. Kill the Process:

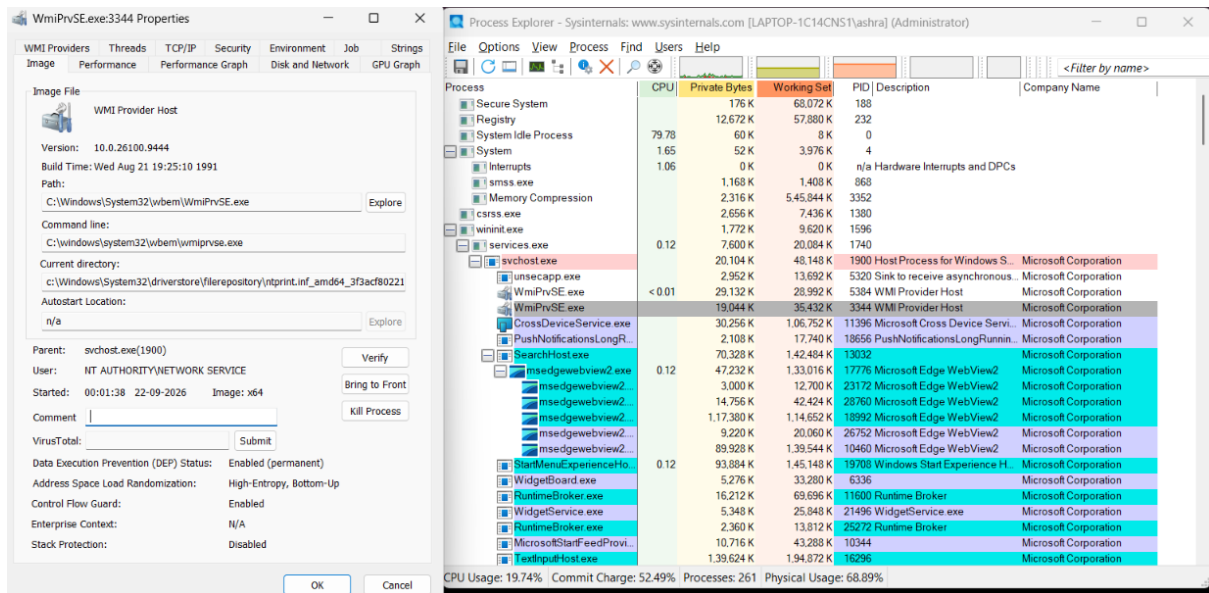
- Right-click the suspicious process and select Kill Process to terminate it immediately.

2. Suspend the Process:

- If you are unsure and want to prevent the process from causing damage while you investigate further, right-click and select Suspend.

3. Remove the Source File:

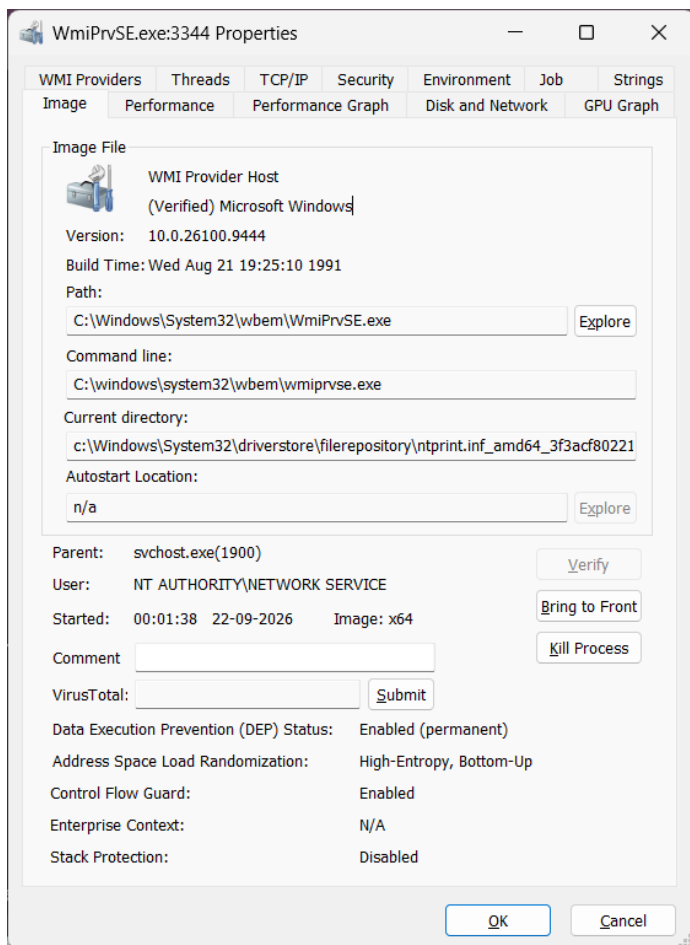
- Go to the location of the file (using the Path from the Properties window) and delete the executable file if confirmed to be malware.
- Be cautious, as some malware might prevent you from deleting it. In such cases, you may need to boot into Safe Mode or use a specialized tool.



Step 6: Scan Your System

After terminating any suspicious processes, it's a good idea to:

- Run a full antivirus scan using trusted antivirus software.
- Use Malware Removal Tools like Malwarebytes or Windows Defender to perform an in-depth scan of your system.



Example of Identifying a Suspicious Process

1. You notice a process called randomname123.exe using an unusually high amount of CPU.
2. Right-click it, select Properties, and find it is running from a suspicious folder, not the system folder.
3. You check the TCP/IP tab and see it is making external connections to unknown IP addresses.
4. A quick search shows that this process is often associated with a specific type of malware.
5. You kill the process and remove the executable file from the system.